Treatment

There is no standard treatment for Parkinson's. Explore the types of treatments available to help you better manage this disease.

💡 Quick Summary

- Treatment for Parkinson's can help manage symptoms and improve daily life, but it does not currently stop or cure Parkinson's.
- Medication is often a key part of symptom management, especially for movement symptoms.
- Exercise, rehabilitation therapy and other approaches can support movement and non-movement symptoms.
- Treatment is individualized and may adapt over time as symptoms and needs change.

How do Parkinson's treatments work?

Parkinson's disease (PD) treatment is individualized and often includes different approaches used over time to help manage symptoms, maintain daily function and support quality of life. While there is currently no cure for Parkinson's, many symptoms can be managed.

There is no single treatment plan that works for everyone. Treatment decisions are made with a care team and adjusted over time based on symptoms, goals and daily needs.

What types of treatments are available for Parkinson's?

Parkinson's treatment often includes a combination of approaches that work together to manage symptoms.

Get Informed

Exercise

Exercise can improve many PD symptoms. It is a vital to maintaining balance, mobility, mental health and activities of daily living for people with Parkinson's.

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Prescription Medications

The choice of medication treatment depends on many variables, including symptoms present. Learn more about the types of available medications.

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Surgical Treatment Options

Looking to explore advanced treatment options? Surgery can be an effective option for managing and improving many movement PD symptoms.

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Medications

Medication is the primary treatment for managing **movement symptoms**. Most people begin with the prescription medication levodopa, though other medications may also be used depending on symptoms and needs.

Doses and timing often vary throughout the day, and treatment plans are commonly adjusted over time. Some medications may also help manage **non-movement symptoms**.

Exercise and Movement

For people living with Parkinson's, **exercise** is an important part of managing symptoms and overall health. Regular physical activity can improve balance, mobility, flexibility, mood and thinking. Exercise programs should be tailored to individual abilities, symptoms and preferences.

Rehabilitation Therapies

Physical, occupational and speech therapies, also called rehabilitation therapies, focus on practical strategies to help maintain safety, independence and quality of life throughout the Parkinson's journey.

- **Physical therapy** uses targeted exercises and movement strategies to help improve strength, balance, walking, flexibility, posture and fall prevention.
- **Occupational therapy** provides strategies, tools and adaptations to help with daily tasks, hand coordination, home safety and staying engaged in meaningful daily activities.
- **Speech therapy** supports voice, communication, swallowing safety and thinking skills.

Palliative or Supportive Care

Palliative care offers added support from a specialized care team that may include doctors, nurses, social workers and other professionals. This support can help manage physical symptoms, emotional well-being, care planning and the needs of both people living with Parkinson's and care partners. It can be helpful at any stage of Parkinson's, not only at the end of life.

Advanced Treatment Options

Advanced treatment options may be considered when medications and other strategies are no longer managing symptoms consistently throughout the day or are causing significant side effects.

- **Pump therapies** deliver medication continuously through a portable pump system to help provide steadier symptom control.
- **Deep brain stimulation (DBS)** is a surgical treatment that delivers electrical stimulation and helps manage certain movement symptoms.
- **Focused ultrasound and other lesion therapies** are procedures that intentionally target small areas of the brain to help reduce specific movement symptoms.

Medical Marijuana

Researchers are testing marijuana, sometimes referred to as cannabis or its components of THC and CBD, as a treatment for many illnesses and diseases, including neurological conditions.

Learn more about the risks and benefits of medical marijuana for people with Parkinson's.

Over the Counter & Complementary Therapies

People with Parkinson's who seek relief from their symptoms may decide to explore **complementary therapies**, which can support or complement traditional medicine. While there are many kinds of complementary medicine, this section focuses on herbs, vitamins and supplements.

Clinical Trials

Research studies test potential new treatments and therapies for Parkinson's. People with Parkinson's can help advance research by participating in trials. Learn more about how clinical trials work, what to expect and whether one may be right for you.

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Management & Lifestyle

Nutrition

Healthy eating can support general health and may help manage Parkinson's symptoms. A balanced **diet** with fruits, vegetables, whole grains, fiber and adequate hydration can help manage constipation, support energy and improve general health. Meal timing may also affect how well Parkinson's medications work. Working with a healthcare professional or dietitian can help address nutrition-related concerns and support symptom management.

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Mental Health Support

Depression, **anxiety** and **apathy** (less motivation) are common non-movement symptoms of Parkinson's disease. Support may include counseling, psychotherapy, support groups, social workers, psychologists, psychiatrists or other mental health professionals. Addressing mood, behavior and emotional well-being can significantly improve quality of life.

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Do treatments change over time?

Parkinson's affects everyone differently, and treatment does not follow one fixed path or stage-based progression.

Many approaches — including medications, exercise, rehabilitation therapies, nutrition support and mental health care — may be helpful from diagnosis onward and continue throughout the journey.

As Parkinson's changes over time, symptoms may become more complex. Medications may need more frequent adjustments, and "off" times may become more common. **"Off" time** happens when medication benefits wear off between doses and symptoms return or worsen.

Treatment changes may include:

- Adjusting medications or timing
- Adding therapies or supportive care
- Increasing help with daily activities
- Considering advanced treatment options

How should I work with a Parkinson's care team?

Regular communication with your **Parkinson's care team** is an important part of treatment. Preparing for appointments and clearly sharing symptoms, medication changes and daily challenges can help guide care decisions.

This can include:

- Tracking symptoms, side effects and medication timing
- Noting when symptoms improve or worsen
- Preparing questions before appointments
- Discussing physical, emotional and daily life challenges
- Asking about therapy, mental health, nutrition or supportive care

Explore Topics

- Learn about **medications**
- Learn about **advanced therapies**
- Explore **exercise** and **rehabilitation therapies**
- Find support for **mood** and **thinking changes**

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